MIXED MESSAGES

Senior BJP and RSS leaders signal an **interest in dialogue with Muslims** in the wake of the crackdown on the PFI. But the politics of polarisation endures

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



ANI

If there is one thing the BJP poll machinery never takes for granted, it's the support of any vote bank. It constantly works on either retaining existing support, or breaking fresh ground among communities. Which is why even as it bans the radical Muslim organisation Popular Front of India (PFI) and is coming down hard on 'illegal' *madrassas*, the party, and the parent organisation Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), are simultaneously reaching out to what they consider the moderate sections of the Muslim community.

Thus it was that on his customary Vijayadashami address on October 5, RSS *sarsanghchalak* Mohan Bhagwat highlighted the organisation's commitment to a sustained dialogue with the minority community. Alleging that a false narrative of minorities being in danger is being propagated, the RSS chief said the Sangh will continue its effort to reach out to them and assuage their fears.

In the past six months, the BJP, too, has made some apparently conciliatory moves towards Muslims, including distancing itself from the controversial remarks party leader Nupur Sharma made about Prophet Muhammad. At the BJP national executive meeting in July, PM Narendra Modi had asked the party leaders to reach out to Pasmanda Muslims, who despite being a majority among the community, remain socially and economically backward. Now, the party is fine-tuning the details of its outreach programme called Sneha Yatra (affection march), to educate the marginalised sections about the Centre's welfare schemes for the poor. The Uttar Pradesh BJP on October 16 also organised a meeting of Pasmanda (or 'left behind') Muslims in Lucknow—projected as the first such initiative in the country—where deputy CM Brajesh Pathak termed the party a "true well-wisher" of Muslims.

For the BJP, a key learning from the 2022 assembly election in UP and the 2021 polls in West Bengal was that the Muslim electorate largely voted en bloc to